PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Lexus GX 470

2003–2009 · J120 · UZJ120 · 2UZ-FE

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame rust**
  Forum veterans call this the biggest concern on trucks from the salt belt. Get underneath with a light and a screwdriver, or ask for close-up photos of the frame. Rust on the rear air-spring perches is also what kills the airbags.
- [ ] **Rear air suspension**
  Look for a rear end that sags overnight, a blinking height-control light, a harsh ride or a compressor that runs constantly. Spray soapy water where each airbag folds over its lower perch. If the system is already converted to coils, ask whose kit was used.
- [ ] **Timing belt history**
  The 2UZ-FE uses a belt that Toyota schedules at 90,000 miles, and the water pump runs off it. If there's no receipt, budget roughly $1K at a shop or a weekend of your own time. Engine Builder classes all belt-driven Toyota V8s as interference engines, so don't gamble on an unknown belt.
- [ ] **Cold-start tick**
  A tick that fades as the engine warms is the classic sign of a cracked exhaust manifold, often on the driver's side. The repair is a big one, so treat it as a price negotiation point.
- [ ] **Steering rack**
  Look for wet rack boots and power-steering fluid on the crossmember, and listen for creaking or whining at full lock. One ClubLexus owner's rack began creaking and whining loudly at about 130k miles.
- [ ] **Front end wear**
  Check for torn lower ball-joint boots and grease slung from the CV boots, and listen for clunks over bumps. Many trucks need lower control arms or ball joints, CV axles and front bearings at this age.
- [ ] **KDSS or not?**
  Turn the key and watch for a momentary KDSS light, or look for the oversized front sway bar. KDSS improves stability and articulation, but some skids and sliders need KDSS-specific versions or modifications.
- [ ] **Dashboard**
  Heat cracks and sticky dashboard surfaces are common enough that Lexus ran a warranty enhancement program for 2003–2008 GX 470s. Check whether the dash was already replaced, and confirm with a dealer whether any coverage still applies.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Side curtain airbag control module**
  2004–2006 · NHTSA 16V-065

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Second-row seat latch (Lexus Link trucks)**
  2003 · NHTSA 03V-088
- [ ] **Incorrect GVWR on certification label**
  2003 · NHTSA 03V-031
- [ ] **Load and GVWR labels on accessorized trucks**
  2009 · NHTSA 09V-234

- [ ] **VIN**
  US trucks start JTJBT20X. NHTSA's vPIC decoder reads the series as UZJ120L, the engine as the 2UZ-FE and the plant as Tahara, Japan. The 10th character is the model year (3 = 2003 through 9 = 2009).
- [ ] **KDSS**
  Optional from late in the 2004 model year and standard on the 2005-on Sport. Look for a momentary KDSS light at key-on and the noticeably large front sway bar.
- [ ] **Hitch rating**
  2003 trucks are rated for 5,000 lb. The stronger frame-bolted tubular hitch arrived during the 2004 model year with a 6,500 lb rating, so check what's actually bolted on.
- [ ] **Sport model**
  From 2005: KDSS, smoked headlamp bezels, extra chrome trim and black birdseye maple wood.
- [ ] **Facelift trucks**
  2008–2009 trucks have the dark metallic grille and liquid-graphite wheels.
- [ ] **Rear suspension**
  Rear air suspension shares its layout with the air-sprung 4th-gen 4Runner. Many trucks have been converted to coils, which is worth knowing before you look for the height-control switch.

NOTES

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